

The First Home Buyer's 90-Day Checklist — South Australia

Everything you need to sort before you sign, in plain English.

Correct as at July 2026. Grant amounts and thresholds are set by government and can change — always confirm current details with RevenueSA (revenuesa.sa.gov.au) before relying on this for a purchase decision. This checklist is general information, not financial or legal advice.

Section 1 — Get Your Foundations Right (Do this first, before house-hunting)

- ☐ [] **Check your borrowing capacity with 2-3 lenders or a mortgage broker.**
- ☐ [] **Check your eligibility for the South Australian First Home Owner Grant.** A one-off **\$15,000** payment for eligible new homes — **with no property value cap** since the cap was removed in February 2025.
- ☐ [] **Understand South Australia's stamp duty position — this is genuinely different from most other states.** Since 6 June 2024, eligible first home buyers pay **\$0 stamp duty on new homes and vacant land, with no value cap at all**. However — and this is important — **SA does not offer a stamp duty exemption or concession for established (existing) homes** for first home buyers. This is unlike VIC, NSW, QLD and WA, which all offer some relief on established homes too.
- ☐ [] **Factor this established-home gap into your buy new vs. buy established decision.** If you're set on an established home, you'll pay full standard stamp duty in SA — a genuinely different calculation to other states, and worth running the numbers on new vs. established before you commit to a search strategy.
- ☐ [] **Check the federal First Home Guarantee price caps for SA.** From 1 October 2025: **\$900,000 for Adelaide**, and **\$500,000 for the rest of South Australia**.
- ☐ [] **Consider the First Home Super Saver Scheme (FHSSS)** if still building your deposit.
- ☐ [] **Look into the SA Rent-to-Buy Affordable Housing Initiative** (2025–26) if relevant — eligible participants can rent selected newly built homes at 75% of market rent for up to two years while saving a deposit, with an option to buy later. This is separate from the FHOG.
- ☐ [] **Get formal pre-approval, not just an estimate.**

Section 2 — While You're Searching

- ☐ [] **Set a firm maximum price** based on your pre-approval.
- ☐ [] **Budget for costs beyond the purchase price:** conveyancing fees, building and pest inspections, loan fees, and moving costs — and remember, if you're buying established, budget for full stamp duty given SA's lack of an established-home concession.

Section 3 — Know Your Legal Protections Before You Sign

- ☐ [] **Understand South Australia's cooling-off period is the shortest in the country.** You generally get just **2 clear business days** after the Form 1 (Vendor's Statement) is served to withdraw — significantly shorter than NSW/QLD's 5 days or Victoria's 3.
- ☐ [] **Know how the 2-day period is calculated.** It runs from when you receive both the signed contract and a complete Form 1 — weekends and public holidays don't count, so if your Form 1 arrives Thursday, your window typically runs to the end of Monday.
- ☐ [] **Know the cooling-off penalty is capped.** If you withdraw during the period, you generally lose a small fee — reported as capped at around \$100 — much cheaper than the percentage-based penalties in NSW, VIC, and QLD.
- ☐ [] **Know cooling-off doesn't apply at auction**, and sellers never have a cooling-off right (it exists solely to protect buyers).
- ☐ [] **Get a building and pest inspection done within your (short) cooling-off window, or before auction day** — given the compressed 2-day timeframe, arranging this promptly is genuinely more time-pressured in SA than in most other states.

Section 4 — Between Signing and Settlement

- ☐ [] **Confirm building insurance timing with your conveyancer.**
- ☐ [] **Finalise unconditional loan approval** well before settlement.
- ☐ [] **Book a pre-settlement inspection** in the days before settlement.
- ☐ [] **Confirm who's lodging your FHOG and stamp duty exemption paperwork.**

Section 5 — Common First-Home-Buyer Mistakes to Avoid

- ☐ [] **Don't assume established homes get a stamp duty break in SA** — they don't; this is one of the biggest state-specific differences to plan around.
- ☐ [] **Don't waste your short cooling-off window** — with just 2 clear business days, you need your inspection and finance queries moving immediately after signing, not "at some point this week."
- ☐ [] **Don't bid at auction without unconditional finance approval** — there's no cooling-off period to fall back on.

Quick Reference — South Australia First Home Buyer Support (July 2026)

SUPPORT	AMOUNT / DETAIL	APPLIES TO
First Home Owner Grant	\$15,000	New homes, no price cap
Stamp duty exemption (new homes/vacant land)	\$0 duty, no cap	Since 6 June 2024

Stamp duty exemption (established homes)	None	SA offers no FHB concession on established homes
First Home Guarantee (federal)	5% deposit, no LMI	≤\$900,000 Adelaide, ≤\$500,000 rest of SA
Cooling-off period	2 clear business days	Shortest in Australia — private treaty only, ~\$100 penalty

Sources: RevenueSA (revenuesa.sa.gov.au), South Australian Government. Always verify current figures before making a purchase decision.

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